Lashkar's relations to the Gulf region stretch back to the time of the anti-Soviet Afghan jihad, when several MDI founders studied in Saudi Arabia. Saudis associated with the group helped Lashkar to expand its networks in the Gulf during the ensuing decade, as did Pakistani and Indian operatives living there. For example, the US government asserts Mahmoud Mohammad Ahmed Bahaziq served as Lashkar's leader in Saudi Arabia at one point. From there he coordinated the group's efforts to raise money from NGOs and local businessmen, and also helped to extend its organizational reach in the Gulf. When the US Treasury Department froze Bahaziq's assets in 2008, it credited him with being 'the main financier behind the establishment of the LET and its activities in the 1980s and 1990s' and alleged that he remained an active contributor to the group's operations during this decade.[130] Several interlocutors with knowledge of Bahaziq's activities seconded this assertion, noting that he was well positioned to support the group's fundraising objectives in the region.[131] As the previous section highlighted, Azam Ghouri also played a role in supporting Lashkar's operations in the Gulf after fleeing to Saudi Arabia from India. The group's relationship with Dawood Ibrahim's criminal syndicate, which had a strong presence in the United Arab Emirates, helped too and brought with it access to smuggling routes and another source from which to acquire counterfeit documents for operatives transiting between different countries.[132]

Lashkar benefited from Gulf funding during the Afghan jihad against the Soviets, and continued to thereafter since its missionary ambitions continued to attract Arab donors interested in supporting the spread of Salafi Islam in South Asia. Exact figures are not available via open sources, but a number of Pakistani-based analysts and Western officials told the author that the largest source of Gulf funding comes from Wahhabi groups in Saudi Arabia. In addition to fundraising based on religious identity, Lashkar's donor base benefited from ethnic ties as well. According to some Lashkar sources, during the 1990s, the Pakistani diaspora in the Gulf contributed even more than their fellow ex-patriots in the United Kingdom.[133] This claim is questionable, and almost impossible to verify using only open source information, but it reinforces the proposition that Gulf funding was not limited to donors who backed the group for religious reasons. Lashkar's various funding networks were already quite robust by the end of the 1990s. According to the US Treasury Department, after Haji